

Three Decades of Culturally Relevant, Responsive, & Sustaining Pedagogy: What Lies Ahead?

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EDITORIAL STATEMENT



Three Decades of Culturally Relevant, Responsive, & Sustaining Pedagogy: What Lies Ahead?

Since 1988 I have been researching what I came to call, “Culturally Relevant Pedagogy” (CRP). This work, that examines the pedagogical expertise of those teachers who are successful with students who have traditionally struggled in US classrooms, has exploded across the country and around the world. The challenge has been to identify teaching practices that have remained faithful to CRP theory. Thus, teaching that focuses on advancing student learning, developing cultural competence, and fostering critical consciousness is the only practice that accurately represents what is meant by Culturally Relevant Pedagogy.

This work was initiated by the national attention being paid to teaching in the mid-1980s. Shulman’s (1987) highly cited article, “Knowledge and teaching” provided a generic look at teaching that focused on content knowledge, pedagogical knowledge, and what Shulman identified as “pedagogical content knowledge.” However, little in Shulman’s work spoke to the specificity of culture and the pedagogical expertise of teachers who were experiencing success with those students who rarely experienced school success. This was the perceived need that Culturally Relevant Pedagogy addressed. To his credit, Shulman chaired the Spencer Fellows selection process that chose my initial proposal on culturally relevant pedagogy.

Although the early work on Culturally Relevant Pedagogy described teaching in elementary classrooms, over time scholars began to see and document outstanding practice in secondary classrooms. Similarly, scholars expanded the work beyond literacy and social studies to include STEAM subject areas (See for example, work of Emdin, Kinloch, Milner, and San Pedro). The point of these applications was to document the usefulness of the work in multiple contexts.

By 2012, Paris (2012) began discussing a new stance on Culturally Relevant Pedagogy he termed, “Culturally Sustaining Pedagogy.” This work saw Culturally Relevant Pedagogy as foundational to creating a pedagogy that explicitly embodied resistance to the status quo and encouraged marginalized communities to fight for their linguistic and cultural sovereignty. This work gained traction and resulted in a volume (Paris & Alim, 2017) that included African American, Latinx, Asian American, Indigenous approaches to culturally sustaining pedagogies.

Another aspect of CRP that has emerged over the last decade is the salience of youth culture and its influence on students, teachers, curriculum, pedagogy and culture *writ large*. The influence of youth culture is evident in the work of scholars such as Christopher Emdin, Bettina Love, Marc Lamont Hill, and others. Emdin’s (2016) critically acclaimed book and hands-on work with the Science Genius program (see, <https://hiphoped.com/science-genius/>) provided an important framework for understanding the power of youth culture to transform teaching and learning.

CRP has gained lots of attention and traction in schools and districts throughout the US. Teacher professional organizations, state departments of education, and individual school districts have endorsed or subscribed to some version of culturally responsive education. Indiana published its “Culturally Responsive Teaching: A Guide to Evidence-Based Practices

for Teaching All Students Equitably” (see <https://www.doe.in.gov/school-improvement/sire-sourcehub/culturally-responsive-teaching-guide-evidence-based-practices>). New York State Department of Education published its, “Culturally Responsive-Sustaining Education Framework” (see <http://www.nysed.gov/bilingual-ed/culturally-responsive-sustaining-education-framework>). The Madison (WI) Metropolitan School District published its “Culturally and Linguistically Responsive Strategies Project” (see <https://accountability.madison.k12.wi.us/files/accountability/CLRP-project-overview-8-1-2014.pdf>). While states, districts, and professional organizations are to be commended for recognizing the need to address issues of cultural relevance, responsiveness, sustainability, most of these top down efforts fall short of the original and subsequent iteration designs of the theory.

Unfortunately, the popularity of culturally relevant, responsive and sustaining pedagogies has led to the creation of workshops, institutes, and certifications designed to “make” teachers culturally relevant (responsive or sustaining) pedagogs. Typically, these bromides are rarely grounded in careful theory and offer desperate teachers, schools, and districts a set of prescriptive approaches that are antithetical to everything the theory represents. This issue is proposed as an anecdote to some of the spurious claims being made by those who do not clearly understand the theory.

I would argue that another place where the practical application of the scholarship has struggled is in the academy. While teacher educators regularly assign readings on culturally relevant, responsive, and sustaining pedagogies, they rarely demonstrate such work in their own teaching and teacher education students and novice teachers report struggling with implementation of the theory in their own practice.

This issue of *The Educational Forum* is comprised of scholars who have been in the forefront of Culturally Relevant, Responsive, Sustaining Pedagogies theory and practice in areas of literacy, mathematics, language, science, social studies, and teacher education. These scholars were chosen because they know the literature, understand the theory, and have been researching and writing in this area for years. Their task is to describe the current state of culturally relevant, responsive and/or sustaining pedagogies in their field(s) and outline some of the existing exemplary practices and challenges. Their work can be methodological, empirical, conceptual, or theoretical. This issue of the journal is designed to bring scholars and practitioners current and spur them to deeper and more creative thinking about CRP/CSP.

In the midst of four pandemics—COVID-19, systemic racism, pending economic collapse, and environmental catastrophe—teachers have the challenge of teaching students who are confronting existential uncertainty and precarious futures. It is a scary and confusing time. Educators are worried about what missing a year and a half of formal, in-person schooling will mean for students, particularly those students we consider to be among the most vulnerable. Bu vulnerable I mean those students who did not have access to reliable wi-fi, quality computer equipment (e.g., laptops, tablets), whose parents served as essential workers (e.g., grocery store clerks, bus drivers, mail carriers, etc.) and who may be food insecure as well as struggling to stay current with school-based learning. Educators may not have taken into account the challenges of students in households with multiple school-aged siblings who may need to share devices. Also, educators may not have considered the fact that high school aged students may have used school closure as an opportunity to secure employment or pick up more hours on a job at which they already worked. All of these factors have forced educators to think differently about their work.

Despite these challenges and uncertainties, I want to suggest that these multiple pandemics also provide the education community with a unique opportunity to re-set and revision our work (Ladson-Billings, 2021). The school stoppage has forced us to acknowledge we were not serving all students well before COVID-19 school closures. The idea that we should “go back to normal” is abhorrent to many students. Before the COVID-19 pandemic, normal for some students represented failure in academic work, regular disciplinary sanctions, the inability to access honors and enriched curriculum. Why would they want to go back to normal? On the other hand, parents of some of these same children declared that during the school closure they received more academically focused contacts—calls, emails, texts, and video conferences—from educators than ever before. Some parents also indicated that their children felt safer at home than at school. Being at home meant being away from bullying, threats, embarrassment, and lack of genuine adult support.

For me, as an architect of culturally relevant pedagogy, the pandemics provide opportunities to reinforce how important it is for educators to develop a coherent pedagogical philosophy and strategy for ensuring that all students reach academic, social, cultural, and civic success. This issue takes up aspects of culturally relevant, culturally sustaining, and culturally revitalizing, and reality pedagogies. It also looks toward the work of teacher educators with both pre-service and in-service teachers. The articles assembled in this issue also speak to what are perceived to be subjects that are not amenable to culturally relevant/sustaining pedagogies, i. e., STEM subjects.

My biggest fear as a teacher educator is that we will fail to take advantage of the opportunities the pandemic has afforded us. I fear we will drift back into old habits and old ways of schooling and not give our students the chance to explore new ways of teaching and learning. We now have the opportunity to move into a more integrated, problem based approach to learning. We have a chance to not react slavishly toward external assessments that fail to accurately reflect the curriculum students experience in their classrooms. Do we have to remind ourselves that we are living in the 21st century and that our children have seen autonomous vehicles, information at the touch of a button, the ability to film and produce their own films and communicate with people around the world. This is a generation who took advantage of this COVID moment and created food delivery services for Black owned restaurants, developed candy companies to help finance their college careers, practiced random acts of kindness for people who could not go to the grocery store, tutored other students in mathematics, and mastered Tik Tok. Yet, our response is to continue to burden them with worksheets and mindless exercises. We insist on giving 21st century students a 19th century education.

Culturally relevant/sustaining/revitalizing/reality pedagogies is designed to cultivate students’ voices, entrepreneurial inclinations, and inventive spirits. These pedagogies are not meant to fit students into neat boxes and categories like, “basic,” “general,” “regular,” “honors,” and “honors plus.” Instead of relentlessly sorting, separating, and ranking students these pedagogies seek to open up worlds of possibilities for each student to bring his or her whole self into the classroom and into the world.

The articles in this issue are not road maps rather they are frameworks. They are exemplars and existence proofs of what is possible. Each time someone says, “we can’t do that,” or “that won’t work,” these articles underscore the reality of possibility. They remind us that smart, dedicated teachers are out there—teachers who are unafraid to swim against the tide. There

are teachers who believe so deeply in students' capacity and possibilities that they will move heaven and earth to ensure that students push toward excellence. They remind us that there are models of teaching beyond lecturing and following the directions of a Teacher's Guide. There are models that draw upon teachers' integrity, creativity, and desire to stimulate the intellectual curiosity of students. These articles highlight teachers and practices that help us reimagine the education of all of our children and particularly the education of those students who have been poorly served by our schools. In the end we want all students to receive the benefit of culturally relevant/sustaining/revitalizing/reality pedagogies.

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